

Chapter 134 - Protection

The moment fingernails scraped across her back, white light had already appeared behind her. The white bone carrying cold frost deflected Li Hanxi's wrist, causing her to cry out in pain and fall backward. Her layered, petal-like skirt spun once in mid-air before she landed awkwardly.

The white bone's force wasn't great, but striking the wrist caused heart-piercing pain. Li Hanxi screamed, her back hair standing on end from the pain.

She was about to rebuke the newcomer when she belatedly recognized the frost, immediately freezing in place. She stared in shock as the woman with ice-cold eyes gracefully descended, blocking Ning Fuyi behind her.

"Are you alright?" Chu Qingqiu turned her head and asked.

The injury truly wasn't serious, but Ning Fuyi didn't say it was nothing. She only said quietly: "Won't die."

"You demon, stop pretending!" Li Hanxi was both angry and sorrowful. "Divine Venerable, don't believe her lies. Flying Flower Sect disciples saw with their own eyes that she was surrounded by demonic energy. Don't be deceived by her appearance!"

Ning Fuyi coughed twice.

"Your injuries haven't healed yet. Are they acting up again?" Hearing her cough, Chu Qingqiu quickly reached out to grasp her arm, her voice full of concern, then used immortal power to probe her meridians.

"Divine Venerable!" Li Hanxi wanted to persuade further, but was silenced by Chu Qingqiu's look, feeling as if stuck in her throat.

"Whether she's a demon or not, can't you see for yourself?" Chu Qingqiu rebuked her softly, raising her hand to embrace Ning Fuyi's shoulders, her sleeves falling to cover half of the woman's body.

Li Hanxi's gaze swept over Chu Qingqiu's protective posture around Ning Fuyi, and a strange feeling immediately surged in her heart, though she didn't dare think too much about it.

Since that incident at Zhaoyan Mountain¹, although Li Hanxi still harbored unrequited feelings for Chu Qingqiu, she ultimately didn't dare to have any more obsessive thoughts. These many years had passed relatively peacefully, but now that the woman had appeared before her again, her heart that had been dormant for years still couldn't hide its trembling.

At this time, Hua Hong, who had been controlling the wooden puppet from afar, sensibly withdrew his divine power. The massive puppet folded itself according to his gestures, finally becoming no bigger than a sparrow-sized tile, jumping into his sleeve by itself.

He approached with a smile and bowed respectfully, but Chu Qingqiu paid him no attention, only saying coldly: "I heard just now that this rumor was spread by Flying Flower Sect?"

Hua Hong's expression immediately became somewhat unnatural, then he laughed awkwardly: "Fairy Hanxi and I were merely eager to eliminate demons. Please don't blame us, Divine Venerable."

"Eager to eliminate demons - does that mean you can harm innocents at will?" Chu Qingqiu raised her eyes.

Hearing this, Hua Hong smiled sheepishly, but his eyes rolled cleverly. Though Chu Qingqiu was indeed a Divine Venerable, the various sect leaders were, after all, also dragons among men, outstanding figures in the immortal world. While they respected her repeated world-saving efforts, they weren't completely subservient to her.

Even if Chu Qingqiu had once possessed supreme cultivation, that was ultimately in the past. The current Chu Ling Divine Venerable was not as powerful as before. Respecting her was giving face, not fear.

"What the Divine Venerable says is correct, but this matter concerns the Six Realms after all. How can we few decide it? In my opinion, why not invite Ning... Hall Master Chuwei² to meet with the immortals? If she truly has no connection with demons, it would clear her name," Hua Hong said with a smile, his words watertight.

Ning Fuyi looked at him like a fox with chicken feathers stuck in it, his small eyes full of calculations.

Chu Qingqiu's dark brows furrowed: "Meeting with the immortals sounds nice, but how is it different from an interrogation?"

"The Divine Venerable speaks too harshly. We're merely considering the bigger picture. If we clear someone's name based on just a few words, it's no different from condemning someone based on just a few words," Hua Hong said. "The Divine Venerable has always been fair and strict. Why today..."

"What about today? Playing favorites?" Chu Qingqiu raised her eyes.

Seeing the atmosphere turn icy, Ning Fuyi suddenly grasped the white bone in Chu Qingqiu's hand: "Divine Venerable."

Then she stepped forward, dimples appearing: "Your obsession with me runs so deep. I've already proven in full view that I'm not a demon, yet you continue to press me relentlessly."

"Don't tell me that from now on, every time you see me, you'll make me prove myself again? Wouldn't that mean even if I prove myself a hundred times, if you say you don't believe it, you won't believe it?" Ning Fuyi said mockingly.

"We immortal sects have many affairs to attend to. How could we have so much energy? You can rest assured," Hua Hong smiled.

Ning Fuyi stared intently into his eyes, her smile never fading. She stared until even Li Hanxi couldn't hold her composure, then finally spoke: "It seems you two are determined to take me away today. If that's the case, please."

She gestured toward Star Point Town.

"At least you know your place!" Li Hanxi said quietly.

"Please," Hua Hong nodded.

"Divine Venerable," Ning Fuyi said as she passed Chu Qingqiu, patting her shoulder to show she shouldn't worry. Chu Qingqiu clenched her palms and followed silently behind.

Star Point Town was as prosperous as it had been decades ago. Perhaps because there were many more immortal sect members, the streets were even more crowded, constantly shoulder-to-shoulder, requiring them to stop in place for quite a while before they could move forward.

"It's been some time since I've returned. This town has many new interesting things," Ning Fuyi had no sense of being in danger, looking around as she walked.

She even pointed at the marriage bridge in the center that was packed with people: "Divine Venerable, look, that's the bridge we walked across together. With so many people standing on it daily, it still hasn't collapsed - truly sturdy!"

Chu Qingqiu said nothing, while Li Hanxi on the side couldn't contain herself anymore, looking toward that marriage bridge and clenching her fists hard.

Thirty years was enough to wash over a town completely. Though it remained largely unchanged, the shops on either side had basically changed appearance. A six-story tower had been erected in the town center, with glazed tiles gleaming in the sunlight and long strings of lanterns hanging from the flying eaves, with faint string music drifting from within the building.

"Flying Flower Tower," Ning Fuyi looked up at the gold-inscribed plaque and smiled. "From the name, it must be Sect Leader Hua's handiwork?"

Hua Hong smiled without speaking, only extending his hand: "Please."

As the group entered, Ning Fuyi clearly noticed dozens of gazes. The originally chatting and laughing diners and serving attendants all turned to look. The previously noisy atmosphere became eerily quiet after her appearance.

Ning Fuyi swept a glance at those people - young people and white-bearded elders alike. From the look in their eyes, she could tell they were all from immortal sects.

Familiar faces sat around the central round table - various sect leaders and family heads who all fell silent upon her entrance, their gazes following closely.

What a fine Hongmen Feast³, Ning Fuyi thought, raising her eyebrows, but her steps didn't deviate even slightly.

She wondered how these people had learned of her plan to return to Star Point Town.

At this moment, Gongsun Mo from the Gongsun family rose with his fan, smiling: "We've been waiting for you all for quite some time. We didn't expect to see the Chu Ling Divine Venerable as well. Forgive our poor reception."

Chu Qingqiu didn't pay much attention, only nodding lightly.

"Come, come, please sit!" He waved his folding fan, and the empty chairs moved out by themselves. The nearby "attendants" stepped forward to fill the teacups before them with tea.

Ning Fuyi pretended not to see their calculating gazes and sat down calmly. Gongsun Mo was smiling as he invited Chu Qingqiu to sit beside him, but Chu Qingqiu acted as if she hadn't seen him and directly sat next to Ning Fuyi.

The smiles on several people's faces stiffened somewhat as they exchanged glances.

Seeing this, Li Hanxi lifted her skirt and sat on Chu Qingqiu's other side.

"Master Tang is unwell today and cannot attend. Besides that, everyone is here, so let's serve the dishes," Hua Hong said after the people present finished their fake pleasantries. He raised his hand, and several attendants brought elegant jade plates, placing them on the table in turns.

"Hall Master Ning," Hua Hong pointed to a cup of golden tea water in front of Ning Fuyi. "Please."

Ning Fuyi picked up the teacup, brought it to her nose to smell, then smiled with red lips, gently turning her wrist to pour all the tea onto the ground.

The expressions of several people varied. Li Hanxi spoke up: "Ning Fuyi, don't be so ungrateful."

But Ning Fuyi didn't respond to her, only holding the teacup and placing it back on the table: "Sect Leader Hua, what can I say? Those sitting here are all the leaders of immortal sects. Why do you all love using such lowly deception? You can't even be forthright and honest - how dare you call yourselves immortal sects?"

The several people at the table had remained silent, some averting their gazes, but Hua Hong's expression remained unchanged as he smiled lightly: "This cup contains nothing but holy water for dealing with demons. If the Hall Master is not a demon, she need only drink it to clear herself. Why be afraid?"

"Afraid?" Ning Fuyi weighed the cup. "I hate trusting you people the most - your words never match your actions. If what's inside isn't holy water, wouldn't I be falling into a trap?"

"Trap? You girl, don't speak so wildly. We respect you and call you Hall Master, but you're just a mere yellow-haired girl⁴. How dare you act this way?" Gongsun Mo slapped his folding fan on the table, the crisp sound ringing in their ears.

Ning Fuyi touched her ears and leaned back in her chair, smiling: "True immortals should have tolerance for others. Only petty people who've been exposed for their true nature become angry from embarrassment."

"You!" Gongsun Mo stood up to grab her but was pulled back by Hua Hong and slowly pressed back into his seat.

Hua Hong stared at Ning Fuyi for a long while, then waved his hand to instruct an "attendant": "Bring the person."

After a while, two attendants walked back to the main hall with their heads lowered, following behind a man. Ning Fuyi looked back and immediately understood what was happening.

The man's steps were unsteady, his face pale - clearly he had suffered internal injuries. Even his expression was very dejected. He looked at Ning Fuyi fearfully and stood beside Hua Hong.

"Hua Feiwu⁵, tell us in detail what you saw and heard that day," Hua Hong pushed him.

"Yes, father." Hua Feiwu swallowed and finally straightened his neck. "That day I was training with Master Tang. On the way to Xuanyuan Kingdom, we encountered this demon. I saw with my own eyes that she was surrounded by rolling demonic energy and nearly injured many people present!"

"Oh yes, she also used demonic energy to burn my brother's hand. The marks on my brother's hand still haven't been removed!" Hua Feiwu raised his voice, pointing at Ning Fuyi.

Ning Fuyi didn't get angry but laughed instead, while Chu Qingqiu secretly gripped her white bone, her eyes stern.

If only he had seen it, it would have been fine - erasing memories wasn't difficult. But many people witnessed it that day, so word spreading was inevitable. Moreover, being so anxious to protect Ning Fuyi that day, there was no time to worry about such things.

But seeing his ungrateful appearance now, Chu Qingqiu only regretted not having done more that day!

"What do you have to say now?" Hua Hong smiled as he tucked his hands into his sleeves. At the same time, the sharp aura around them grew stronger, and those immortal sect disciples disguised as diners all turned toward her, as if waiting for a single command to pounce.

"Sect Leader Hua, don't waste words with this demon anymore, be careful of further trouble!" Gongsun Mo was impatient by nature and immediately slammed the table, his energy scattering the jade objects on the table.

With the crackling sound of shattering, the brush in his palm quickly wrote black characters, then struck out with one palm. Those characters became like seals, overwhelming Ning Fuyi. The others quickly flew back to give themselves room to cast spells.

But at the same time, white light suddenly appeared. The white jade staff broke through the wind, shattering those characters while the airflow made everyone lean sideways, even causing the surrounding tables and chairs to flip and fly up, smashing into walls and splitting apart.

As the strong wind gradually subsided, everyone finally blocked the wind and opened their eyes, only to see Chu Qingqiu standing in front of Ning Fuyi, white robes fluttering, the white jade staff slowly raised horizontally, her gaze ice-cold and piercing.

Everyone was somewhat confused. Gongsun Mo put down his brush and angrily said: "What does the Divine Venerable mean by this!"

"Divine Venerable!" Li Hanxi on the side also became anxious. "Don't let this demon deceive you with sweet words. Your wisdom is boundless - you must not believe her lies. Only by letting us capture this demon can we ensure peace in the Six Realms!"

"Silence." Chu Qingqiu's voice was calm and cold. The white jade staff rotated slightly, and white light behind her condensed into form, creating a huge flower-shaped flowing light that formed a barrier before those menacing immortal sect disciples.

She slightly raised her left arm and took Ning Fuyi's hand, saying softly: "I'd like to see who dares!"

Footnotes:

1. **招摇山 (Zhaoyan Mountain)** - A location mentioned earlier in the story where immortal sects gather.
2. **懔畏堂 (Chuwei Hall)** - Ning Fuyi's position/title, meaning something like "Hall of Awe and Fear."
3. **鸿门宴 (Hongmen Feast)** - A famous historical reference to a banquet that was actually a trap, from the story of Liu Bang and Xiang Yu.
4. **黄毛丫头 (yellow-haired girl)** - A derogatory term for a young, inexperienced girl.
5. **花非雾 (Hua Feiwu)** - Character name meaning "Flower, Not Mist."